Spotlight Transcript: India-Switzerland

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Chapter 1: Introduction to Relations

[0:03] Anchor (Nishit Kumar): Spotlight. [music] This is Akashwani. In the program spotlight, now we bring you a discussion on strengthening India Switzerland bilateral ties. The participants are professor Anshu Joshi, international affairs expert and Nishit Kumar, anchor.

President Guy Parmelin is on a state visit to India from the 5th of October to 7th of October and this marks a major milestone focused on celebrating the first anniversary of the historic India Switzerland relations EFTA India trade and economic partnership agreement that is TEPA and to discuss more about it we are privileged to have been joined in by professor Anshu Joshi international affairs expert. Professor Joshi welcome to the show.

[0:52] Prof. Anshu Joshi: Thank you so much Nishit.

[0:59] Anchor: So professor Joshi, we'd like to begin that how would you assess the **trajectory** of the India Switzerland relations in recent years and what **significance** does the Swiss president's state visit hold for taking the bilateral partnership to a new level?

Chapter 2: Deepening Diplomatic Ties

[1:13] Prof. Anshu Joshi: Nishit, India and Switzerland when we look at the diplomatic bilateral relationship between the two nations both the nations share a long-standing very friendly partnership which has deep roots in the similar values like democratic values and now we can see that the president of Switzerland is on official visit to India which has given a new **momentum** to this you know **overarching** bilateral partnership between the two nations pans around not only good diplomatic relationship wherein both the nations signed treaty of friendship on August 14, 1948 and both the nations have also observed high level visits to the another trajectory of economic and trade ties.

Wherein the trade and economic partnership agreement TEPA was signed between India and European free trade association EFTA and that's where kind of you know an opportunity can be seen of US dollar 100 billion to be invested in India and create 1 million direct jobs in next 15 years. Tool like investment volumes wherein we can see Swiss direct investment in India which stands past CHF 10 billion and almost 350 to 400 Swiss companies are actively operating in Indian market presently to another sector of **strategic** and emerging **collaboration** wherein be it about collaboration in the area of new technologies like AI to like science and tech collaborations to you know strategic or defense collaboration we can see that in last 12 years the trajectory between the two nations have scaled new heights.

Chapter 3: Bilateral Agreements

[4:14] Anchor: Professor Joshi, we just heard Prime Minister Modi talk about the various points on which you know India and Switzerland have inked and just to name a few the MOU was signed on migration and mobility partnership that is MMP agreement on exchange of a young professional. This is very important professor Joshi because this agreement actually aims to govern the exchange of young professionals be taking up temporary employment in the country to enhance their professional and language skills. Another point was the letter of intent between the department on science and technology and Swiss national science foundation. Now this IIA that is implementation agreement this aims to establish you know bilateral cooperation in innovation technology transfer so on and so forth. How do you see this?

Chapter 4: Focus on Key Sectors

[5:26] Prof. Anshu Joshi: Right. We can see both scale and speed wherein we have seen that after the talks that have held between the heads of the two states. Both the nations have announced key five cooperation instruments which cover migration and mobility opportunities for young professionals scientific research increasing connectivity so working together in transportation technologies innovation and entrepreneurship. And that's where we can see that all these key agreements indicate towards a growing shift in India Switzerland relations. So be it about EFTA or TEPA or be it about the potential of investment of Switzerland in India. Our prime minister has announced that you know TEPA has the potential to provide USD 100 billion in investments into India and create 1 million direct jobs in next 15 years which is like a **prioritized** agenda for India.

And apart from that a very significant outcome of this visit is the agreement in the area of migration and mobility. So it's migration and mobility partnership which actually aims to strengthen cooperation while addressing irregular migration, human **exploitation** and trafficking. So that's where this key agreement provides multiple entry visas valid up to 5 years with stays of up to 6 months and each visit along with renewable one-year student permits. So I mean there is something for everyone and a separate young professionals agreement has also been signed and infrastructure and mobility partnership agreement also has been signed wherein India's ministry of road transport and highways and Switzerland's federal department of economic affairs they have signed this key agreement.

And that's where we also see a large infrastructure expansion of India which is underway. So there would be now a greater participation by Swiss companies in all these projects and that's where we can see a **symbiotic** relationship or win-win situation for both the nations. Beyond economics and technologies strategic cooperation was also on the card on the diplomatic table and new possibilities have been identified for military exchanges and defense production. So all in all I can see that be it about the scale of collaboration or speed of collaboration in the next 10 to 15 years we can see **humongous** opportunities.

Chapter 5: Future Strategic Goals

[9:05] **Anchor:** Right, Professor Joshi. We just heard the Swiss president talk about the growing cooperation, the growing closeness between India and Switzerland. So professor Joshi, how can India and Switzerland transform their traditionally strong economic relationship into a broader maybe a strategic partnership **encompassing** technology, innovation, education skills and of course global governance?

[9:38] **Prof. Anshu Joshi:** That's a very good question Nishit and let me tell you when there is trust between the two nations it works as the foundation stone of promoting or elevating bilateral relationship to strategic partnership and there are four core pillars of strategic partnership between any two nations which span around defense and security partnership in the area of science and technology partnership in the sector of energy and of course trade relations.

Now we see that both the nations are also keen to elevate their collaboration in the area of emerging technologies like artificial intelligence. So for example, both the nations have coordinated closely on various AI initiatives. Joint cooperation continues through frameworks like Indo-Swiss joint research program wherein the focus now lies on **sustainability**, promoting green and clean energy, collaborating in space tech and nuclear research as well. And last but not the least, we should not forget the core cornerstone of diplomatic relationship from where the trust comes into the relationship.

Chapter 6: EFTA-TEPA Significance

[12:00] Anchor: Professor Joshi there has been a lot talk about the EFTA and TEPA the partnership agreement the historic trade and economic partnership agreement with the European free trade association EFTA countries. We would like to understand the EFTA and TEPA system how does it work and how is it so important for India in the shadow of what Trump was doing with us and the kind of **punitive** measures he imposed on countries like India?

[12:40] Prof. Anshu Joshi: Signing EFTA which is like India European free trade association trade and economic partnership agreement TEPA that came into a force in October 2025 to signing mother of all these free trade agreement and a historic defense deal with European Union that's where India actually marked a huge **accomplishment** wherein it not only found key block of countries for investments to explore its market as well as promoting its strategic and defense ties.

So that's where the agreement which was signed by EFTA members when I talk about EFTA in particular Switzerland, Norway, Liechtenstein and Iceland, it actually is a major **framework** that promotes investment bilaterally. And Indian exports would also get new markets for our agricultural products, textiles, different goods, pharmaceuticals and so on to Switzerland while also inviting Swiss investments.

Chapter 7: Conclusion

[14:19] Anchor: Thank you so very much professor Joshi for having joined us and shared your views on the topic.

[14:26] Outro: You were listening to a discussion on strengthening India Switzerland bilateral ties. The participants were professor Anshu Joshi, international affairs expert and Nishit Kumar anchor. This program was produced and presented by the news services division of Akashwani. You can listen to it on our mobile app news on air.